

A Short Story: In Philpot Lane [C2]

A Londra, una piccola statua di due topolini che mangiano del formaggio onora la memoria di due operai che trasformarono un'antipatia personale in una tragedia.



Bob reached the top of the [ladder](#) just as dawn appeared on the eastern horizon. The air was ice cold and frost [gleamed](#) on the wooden planks of the [scaffolding](#).

He was glad of his gloves. Bob always arrived before the other builders so that he could hide his [knapsack](#). He never talked much to the other workmen on any site, but this time it was worse. Jem, the gang leader, was a [cocky](#), belligerent man, who had [taken against](#) Bob and used him as [the butt of his jokes](#). He'd twice hidden Bob's [knapsack](#) and Bob was sure that Jem had taken his best [chisel](#). The other builders also [resented](#) the compliments Bob received from the Master Mason. Bob opened his [knapsack](#) and took out his tools, [slotting the chisels](#) into his belt and weighing the [sturdy mallet lovingly](#) in his hand. Made of gleaming [lignum vitae](#), the head was small, but the dense wood was heavy and powerful. Leaving his flask of beer and his lunch of bread and cheese inside, he rolled the [canvas knapsack](#) into [a tight bundle](#) and [stowed](#) it carefully under a plank, away from [vermin](#) — both [rodent](#) and human. As Bob set to work finishing off a piece of delicate moulding, the sky brightened steadily and the [rumble](#) of [cartwheels drifted up](#) from Eastcheap. Just as the sun flamed up over the [docks](#), Jem's [fleshy](#) face appeared at the top of the [ladder](#). "Well, look who's here! [Bootlicker](#) Bob is hard at work, boys!" "All right, Jem?" Bob knew it was best not to react. "Oh, I'm all right, what about you? You left your [missus](#) all cold and alone so early in the morning? I'd better send young Nat round to warm her up!" Young Nat, the youngest builder in the gang, had just climbed up behind Jem and [his face split into a grin](#). Luckily there came [a sharp whistle](#) from the street. Jem [peered over](#) the edge. "Ready, Joe!" He turned to Bob. "Joe and Frank have got some [Portland](#) on the [hoist](#); give us a hand, will you?" Bob nodded and followed Jem to the top of the [hoist](#). Two skinny rats [streaked](#) along one of the [uprights](#). Bob [lashed out](#) with his [lignum vitae](#) hammer, missing the rats completely and [skidding](#) slightly on the frozen planks. He wished he'd been [aiming for](#) Jem's head. He, Jem and Nat guided the bucket of cement onto the [scaffolding](#). "You two take this round to the Philpot Lane side," said Jem. "What about you?" Bob never liked leaving his [knapsack](#) when Jem was around. "There's another bucket coming!" Jem [glared](#) at him. So Bob and Nat [inched the heavy bucket along](#) the platform. By the time they got back to the [hoist](#), Joe and Frank were standing at the top of the [ladder gazing](#) at Jem, who seemed to be returning from the other end of the platform where Bob had been working. Jem grinned. "Rats! I hate them!" he said loudly. "Just kicked those two into the Thames." He saw Bob's expression and [frowned](#). "Something wrong, Bob?" Bob shook his head and marched to his end of the [scaffolding](#). Behind him, the other men laughed. Fiction

A Short Story: Postcard Una cartolina anonima dà libero sfogo all'immaginazione della nostra protagonista. Sarà pronta a conoscere la verità? Rachel Roberts, Rachel Roberts "He hides his [knapsack](#)!" Jem [mocked](#). "Thinks we're going to [nick](#) his stuff!" Bob checked on his [knapsack](#) as soon as the other men were busy. It was still there. He began to [chisel](#) away at the moulding, finishing off any rough edges. It was the job the Mason had given him because he had a delicate hand and was patient. The work was absorbing and he soon forgot about Jem and the others. He glanced up only once at the sound of [pattering feet](#) — the rats Jem was

supposed to have kicked into the Thames, but evidently hadn't. He didn't look up again until the bell of St. Magnus's church told him it was time for lunch. He pulled his gloves off with his teeth, untied his [knapsack](#) and sat on the edge of the platform. He took a long drink of beer and realised he was starving! Reaching again into his pack, he [felt for](#) his bread and cheese — they were gone. Jem! Bob [flung down](#) his [knapsack](#) and marched, [lignum vitae mallet](#) in hand, to the other end of the platform where the others were eating their own sandwiches. "Jem!" Bob shouted. "Where's my bloody lunch?" Jem looked up, [outraged](#). "You calling me a thief?" Bob smacked the [mallet](#) into the palm of his hand. "I know you took it!" Jem [leapt to his feet](#) and marched towards him, but Bob was ready. He smacked Jem on the arm with his [mallet](#). Jem [roared](#) and launched himself at Bob. For a minute they fought furiously, until Jem [seized hold](#) of Bob's arm and [wrenched](#) the [mallet](#) from his [grasp](#). The effort sent him [sliding backwards](#) over the icy planks. He skidded to the edge of the [scaffolding](#), still [clutching](#) Bob's [sleeve](#), and [slipped right over](#). Feeling himself [dragged](#) towards the edge, Bob grabbed one of the steel [uprights](#), but it was wet with melted frost. His ungloved fingers slipped straight off and the two men [tumbled](#) through the air with an [ear-splitting](#) scream. Nat, Frank and Joe [sat frozen to the spot](#). They were too shocked to notice the [scampering](#) of tiny feet as two skinny rats [tussled](#) triumphantly with a hunk of bread and cheese.

THE TWO MICE EATING CHEESE

On a building in Philpot Lane in London, on the corner of Eastcheap Street, the city's smallest public sculpture can be found. It depicts two mice eating cheese, and supposedly commemorates the death of a workman, or possibly two workmen, who are said to have fallen from [scaffolding](#) on the site. According to some, this happened during the construction of the building that hosts the sculpture, in 1862. Legend has it that the workmen were arguing over the theft of a sandwich, which was later revealed to have been taken by mice.

Glossary

- **aiming for** = mirare a
- **gazing** = fissare
- **roared** = ruggire
- **canvas** = tela
- **fleshy** = paffuta
- **streaked** = scattare
- **outraged** = indignato
- **taken against** = prendere in antipatia
- **drifted up** = salire
- **skidding** = scivolare
- **inched the heavy bucket along** = avanzare lentamente
- **scaffolding** = impalcatura
- **nick** = rubacchiare
- **slipped right over** = scivolare oltre
- **pattering feet** = passi rapidi
- **grasp** = presa
- **a sharp whistle** = un fischio acuto
- **knapsack** = zaino
- **rodent** = roditori
- **lashed out** = inveire, attaccare
- **mocked** = prendere in giro
- **slotting the chisels into** = incastrare, inserire
- **mallet** = mazzuolo, martello
- **uprights** = montanti
- **sturdy** = robusto
- **vermin** = parassiti, animali nocivi
- **hoist** = carrucola
- **felt for** = cercare tastando
- **wrenched** = strappare
- **a tight bundle** = un fagotto stretto
- **gleamed** = risplendere
- **cartwheels** = carriole
- **flung down** = scagliare, gettare
- **leapt to his feet** = balzare in piedi
- **seized hold** = afferrare
- **stowed** = riporre, mettere via
- **rumble** = rumore
- **Portland** = cemento Portland
- **sleeve** = manica
- **tumbled** = precipitare

- **peered over** = sporgersi oltre
- **clutching** = stringere
- **dragged** = trascinare
- **cocky** = arrogante
- **frowned** = aggrottare le sopracciglia
- **ear-splitting** = assordante
- **ladder** = scala
- **resented** = serbare rancore
- **Bootlicker** = leccapiedi
- **docks** = moli
- **glared** = fulminare con lo sguardo
- **scampering** = sgattaiolare
- **sliding backwards** = scivolare all'indietro
- **sat frozen to the spot** = restare impietrito
- **tussled** = azzuffarsi
- **the butt of his jokes** = il bersaglio delle sue battute
- **chisel** = scalpello
- **lovingly** = con cura
- **his face split into a grin** = il suo volto si illuminò con un sorriso
- **missus** = signora
- **lignum vitae** = legno di guaiaco